

Integral Relations among Totient Sections

Finite-level bases and bounded residue series

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ABSTRACT

We give integral coordinates for the sections $n \mapsto \varphi(k^j n + r)$ through any fixed level $e \geq 1$, in every integer base $k \geq 2$. A retained family of $k^e + 1$ sections is a basis, and the scalar reductions of the other indexed sections form a basis of all integral relations. We give a finite-evaluation proof of independence and explain its relation to Martin's stronger affine theorem. Prime isolation also classifies rational binary series of dyadic totient residues. The irrationality of the unreduced binary totient series remains open.

1 Introduction

Splitting the totient sequence into its even and odd subsequences, then splitting once more, gives seven sequences:

$$\varphi(n); \quad \varphi(2n), \varphi(2n+1); \quad \varphi(4n), \varphi(4n+1), \varphi(4n+2), \varphi(4n+3).$$

Two identities remove two of them:

$$\varphi(4n) = 2\varphi(2n), \quad \varphi(4n+2) = \varphi(2n+1).$$

The five remaining sequences are linearly independent over $\mathbb{Q}$. Thus every rational linear identity among the seven follows from these two substitutions. If the original coefficients are integers, so are the coefficients obtained after substitution.

The same description holds at every finite depth and in every base. For an integer $k \geq 2$, the *totient sections* are the sequences $n \mapsto \varphi(k^j n + r)$, where $j \geq 0$ and $0 \leq r < k^j$. Throughout, n ranges over $\mathbb{N} = \{0, 1, 2, \dots\}$ and $\varphi(0) = 0$. To describe relations we retain a separate index for each pair (j, r) , even when two pairs give the same sequence. For example, $\varphi(4n+2)$ and $\varphi(2n+1)$ are equal sequences but occupy different positions in the list above.

The sections form the k -kernel of the totient sequence. A sequence is k -regular when the $\mathbb{Z}$ -module generated by its k -kernel is finitely generated [1]. Coons proved that the totient sequence is not k -regular for any $k \geq 2$ [2, Thm. 3.2]. The theorem below gives more explicit information: which sections to retain, how to reduce each of the others, and hence how to test a linear identity. The level-zero family contains only $\varphi(n)$ and has dimension one.

**Authorship and AI use.* Will Cook built and directed the research infrastructure and reviewed the claims when he could. AI agents did most of the research and drafting. Cook did not independently verify every claim.

Theorem 1.1 (A basis through each finite level). [Lean](#) · [Comparator](#) Let $k \geq 2$ and $e \geq 1$ be integers, write $F_{j,r}^{(k)}(n) = \varphi(k^j n + r)$, and put

[Lean](#)
[Comparator](#)

$$V_{k,e} = \text{span}_{\mathbb{Q}} \{ F_{j,r}^{(k)} : 0 \leq j \leq e, 0 \leq r < k^j \}.$$

Then $\dim_{\mathbb{Q}} V_{k,e} = k^e + 1$, and

$$\mathcal{B}_{k,e} = \{F_{0,0}^{(k)}, F_{1,0}^{(k)}\} \cup \{F_{j,r}^{(k)} : 1 \leq j \leq e, 1 \leq r < k^j, k \nmid r\}$$

is a basis. Every omitted section reduces to a basis element by an explicit scalar: $F_{j,0}^{(k)} = k^{j-1} F_{1,0}^{(k)}$ for $j \geq 1$, and if $r = k^t u$ with $t = \max\{s : k^s \mid r\} \geq 1$ and $k \nmid u$, then

$$F_{j,r}^{(k)} = C_k(t, u) F_{j-t,u}^{(k)}, \quad C_k(t, u) = k^t \prod_{\substack{p \mid k \\ p \nmid u}} \left(1 - \frac{1}{p}\right).$$

The condition $k \nmid r$ allows residues with $\gcd(k, r) > 1$. For instance, $r = 1$ and $r = 2$ are both retained in base six, and the reductions involving them are

$$\varphi(36n + 6) = 2\varphi(6n + 1), \quad \varphi(36n + 12) = 4\varphi(6n + 2).$$

The second multiplier includes the factor 2 already present in $6n + 2$. Repeated prime factors of k cause no further exception to the product formula, so the theorem also applies to nonsquarefree bases.

Martin’s 2006 theorem on simultaneous totient inequalities already implies independence for every finite family of pairwise nonproportional affine forms with positive integral slopes [4, Thm. 1]. Its conclusion is stronger than the independence used here. The point of the present description is the explicit reduction of the sections and the integral relation basis in Corollary 3.1. We also give a direct proof that constructs a nonsingular evaluation matrix. It uses the CRT–Dirichlet separation argument in Yazdani’s proof of Theorem 2, credited there to Shallit [12, pp. 652–653]. The step that needs care is to keep the progression for the selected affine form reduced while imposing prime divisors on all the others.

Section 2 proves the basis theorem. Section 3 starts with the six reductions in base six and derives the integral relation basis. In Section 4 we use prime isolation again, for bounded functions of totient residues. The series

$$S = \sum_{n \geq 1} \frac{\varphi(n)}{2^n}$$

has unbounded coefficients. Its irrationality, asked in Erdős Problem #249 [10, p. 61], remains open. The coefficient basis supplies no irrationality conclusion for this value. Appendix A gives further coefficient consequences; Appendices B and C collect the tail identities, comparison sequences and still-unproved cancellation estimates relevant to S. Their longer proofs are in *The Binary Totient Series*.

2 Proof of the basis theorem

Scalar reductions

Multiplication by a power of k changes a totient by a predictable factor once we know which primes dividing k are already present. For a zero residue, kn and $k^j n$ have the same prime divisors when $n > 0$. Hence $\varphi(k^j n) = k^{j-1} \varphi(kn)$; both sides vanish at $n = 0$. For an omitted positive residue $r = k^t u$ with $t \geq 1$ and $k \nmid u$, we have $t < j$ because $0 < r < k^j$. Put $m = k^{j-t} n + u$. A prime $p \mid k$ divides m exactly when it divides u . The product formula for $\varphi(k^t m)/\varphi(m)$ therefore contributes k^t and one factor $1 - 1/p$ for each prime $p \mid k$ absent from u . This is $C_k(t, u)$, and proves spanning.

Affine independence

For independence, Martin's theorem is enough. For any ordering of pairwise nonproportional affine forms and any $C > 0$, it gives a set of positive lower density on which each successive totient ratio exceeds C . In a proposed nonzero relation, place a nonzero coefficient c_1 first and take $C > \max(1, \sum_{i>1} |c_i|/|c_1|)$. The first term then dominates the sum of all remaining terms in absolute value, a contradiction [4, Thm. 1]. This also proves independence after any finite prefix is deleted.

The direct proof below gives a finite witness to independence: a square matrix of evaluations with nonzero determinant. Let $L_i(n) = a_i n + b_i$ for $1 \leq i \leq s$, where $a_i > 0$ and $a_i b_j - a_j b_i \neq 0$ for $i \neq j$. A shift of n makes all the b_i positive and leaves these cross determinants unchanged. Write $g_i = \gcd(a_i, b_i)$ and $A_i = L_i/g_i$, so A_i is primitive. We will choose a prime ℓ and points $n_1, \dots, n_s$ for which

$$E = (\varphi(L_j(n_i)))_{1 \leq i, j \leq s} \equiv \begin{pmatrix} \varphi(g_1) & 0 & \cdots & 0 \\ 0 & \varphi(g_2) & \cdots & 0 \\ \vdots & \vdots & \ddots & \vdots \\ 0 & 0 & \cdots & \varphi(g_s) \end{pmatrix} \pmod{\ell}, \quad \ell \nmid \prod_i \varphi(g_i). \quad (1)$$

A rational relation among the sequences would give a vector in the kernel of E . The displayed congruence makes its determinant nonzero, so no such relation can exist.

Here is how to obtain row i . To make an off-diagonal entry vanish, it suffices to give $L_j(n_i)$ a prime divisor $q_{ij} \equiv 1 \pmod{\ell}$: then $q_{ij} - 1$ divides its totient. To keep the diagonal entry nonzero, we make $A_i(n_i)$ a prime congruent to 2 modulo ℓ . Choose an odd ℓ dividing none of the slopes a_i , the products $g_i \varphi(g_i)$ or the nonzero cross determinants. For each fixed i , Dirichlet's theorem supplies distinct primes $q_{ij} \equiv 1 \pmod{\ell}$ ($j \neq i$) outside the same finite exceptional set. We impose

$$A_i(n) \equiv 2 \pmod{\ell}, \quad L_j(n) \equiv 0 \pmod{q_{ij}} \quad (j \neq i).$$

Each congruence is soluble because its slope is coprime to its modulus. CRT combines them into $n = n_0 + Ru$, where $R = \ell \prod_{j \neq i} q_{ij}$.

Dirichlet's theorem must now be applied to the values of A_i , rather than to n . These values form the progression

$$A_i(n_0 + Ru) = A_i(n_0) + (a_i/g_i)Ru.$$

It remains to check that its initial value and step are coprime. Primitivity excludes the prime factors of a_i/g_i , and the residue 2 excludes the odd prime ℓ . A prime q_{ij} cannot divide $A_i(n_0)$: it would then divide both $L_i(n_0)$ and $L_j(n_0)$, hence

$$a_i L_j(n_0) - a_j L_i(n_0) = a_i b_j - a_j b_i,$$

contrary to its choice. This accounts for every prime factor of the step. We may therefore choose $p = A_i(n_i)$ prime, as large as needed, and in particular with $p \nmid g_i$. Then

$$\varphi(L_i(n_i)) = \varphi(g_i)(p-1) \equiv \varphi(g_i) \not\equiv 0 \pmod{\ell},$$

while all the other entries of row i vanish modulo ℓ . The rows are chosen independently. Each requires one prime value, not simultaneous prime values of all the forms. This proves (1), including with every n_i beyond any prescribed threshold.

The two zero-residue sections

It remains to separate $\varphi(n)$ and $\varphi(kn)$, whose affine arguments are proportional. On the progression $n = km + 1$ we have $\varphi(kn) = \varphi(k)\varphi(n)$, so a proposed relation contains only one zero-residue term after this restriction. The positive-residue sections become the forms

$$k^{j+1}m + k^j + r \quad (k \nmid r),$$

together with $km + 1$. These are pairwise nonproportional: equality of two intercept-to-slope ratios would give $r/k^j = r'/k^{j'}$, which for $j' > j$ forces $k \mid r'$. No positive-residue form is proportional to $km + 1$. Affine independence eliminates every positive-residue coefficient and leaves $A + B\varphi(k) = 0$, where A, B multiply $\varphi(n), \varphi(kn)$. We now evaluate the remaining relation at $n = k$ to obtain $A + Bk = 0$. Since $\varphi(k) < k$, the two equations force $A = B = 0$. Finally,

$$|\mathcal{B}_{k,e}| = 2 + \sum_{j=1}^e (k^j - k^{j-1}) = k^e + 1,$$

which completes the proof of Theorem 1.1. For independence on a tail, use a sufficiently large power of k in the last evaluation.

3 Integral relations

The scalar reductions make an equality test possible without choosing evaluation points. We first carry it out in base six at level two, where there are 43 indexed sections. The 37 retained sections are $F_{0,0}, F_{1,0}$, the five $F_{1,r}$ ($1 \leq r \leq 5$), and the 30 sections $F_{2,r}$ with $1 \leq r < 36$ and $6 \nmid r$. The omitted sections satisfy

$$\begin{aligned} F_{2,0} &= 6F_{1,0}, & F_{2,6} &= 2F_{1,1}, & F_{2,12} &= 4F_{1,2}, \\ F_{2,18} &= 3F_{1,3}, & F_{2,24} &= 4F_{1,4}, & F_{2,30} &= 2F_{1,5}. \end{aligned}$$

Thus an integral combination of the 43 sections vanishes precisely when these six substitutions leave all 37 retained coefficients zero. The six differences obtained by moving the right-hand sides to the left give every integral relation. Indeed, subtracting

the original coefficient of each omitted section times its difference removes all six omitted coordinates. The remaining retained coordinates must then vanish by Theorem 1.1. Writing $x_{j,r}$ for the original coefficient of $F_{j,r}$, the coefficient at $F_{1,2}$ after substitution is $x_{1,2} + 4x_{2,12}$. The separate coefficient $x_{2,12}$ is the coefficient of the relation $E_{2,12} - 4E_{1,2}$, where $E_{j,r}$ denotes the formal generator at index (j,r) . The other omitted indices work in the same way. At base two and level two this gives just $E_{2,0} - 2E_{1,0}$ and $E_{2,2} - E_{1,1}$.

Corollary 3.1 (Integral coordinates and all integral relations). [Lean](#) · [Comparator](#) *Let $k \geq 2$ and $e \geq 1$. The retained family is a $\mathbb{Z}$ -basis of the module generated by the sections through level e . Index the sections by their level and residue, retaining distinct indices even when they define equal sequences. For each omitted index i , write the scalar reduction as $F_i = a_i F_{j(i)}$, where $j(i)$ is retained and a_i is a nonnegative integer. In the free abelian group with one generator E_i for each of these indices, the vectors*

[Lean](#)
[Comparator](#)

$$R_i = E_i - a_i E_{j(i)} \quad (i \text{ omitted})$$

form a $\mathbb{Z}$ -basis of the kernel of evaluation $E_i \mapsto F_i$. In particular, every integral relation has a unique integral expression in these elementary relations, and their rank is $\sum_{j=1}^{e-1} k^j$.

Proof. Since $\prod_{p|k, p \nmid u} p$ divides k , every scalar $C_k(t, u)$ is an integer. The retained family therefore spans the section module over $\mathbb{Z}$, and its rational independence makes it a $\mathbb{Z}$ -basis.

For any vector $x = \sum_i x_i E_i$, subtracting $\sum_{i \text{ omitted}} x_i R_i$ leaves only retained coordinates. At a retained index j , the new coefficient is

$$x_j + \sum_{\substack{i \text{ omitted} \\ j(i)=j}} a_i x_i.$$

Thus the substitutions give the integral coordinates explicitly. If x evaluates to zero, these new coefficients all vanish by independence, so $x = \sum_{i \text{ omitted}} x_i R_i$. Conversely, the coefficient at omitted index i in $\sum_h c_h R_h$ is c_i itself, so we recover every coefficient without division. This proves both independence and uniqueness. Counting omitted indices gives $(1 + k + \dots + k^e) - (k^e + 1) = \sum_{j=1}^{e-1} k^j$. $\square$

The assertion concerns the module generated by the sections. It need not contain every integer-valued sequence in its rational span: for $k = 2$ and $e \geq 2$, the sequence $\varphi(4n + 3)/2$ is integer-valued and has coefficient $1/2$ in the retained basis. Thus this module is not saturated in the group of integer-valued sequences.

An alternative is to test equality at finitely many inputs. Return to base six and level two. Order the retained columns as above, with residues increasing within each level, and evaluate at $n = 0, \dots, 36$ to obtain a 37×37 matrix. Its determinant is 17 modulo 101, so it is nonsingular over $\mathbb{Q}$ and detects every nonzero retained combination at one of these inputs. The script `scripts/totient_kernel_normal_form.py` calculates the coordinates and the first such input using integer arithmetic. The equality test uses the integer evaluations. Reducing the proposed combination modulo 101 would miss $101F_{2,2}$, for example, although its value at $n = 0$ is 101.

4 Bounded functions of totient residues

The prime-isolation construction has a second use. It can place a nonzero totient residue between arbitrarily long blocks of zero residues. For a series with bounded integer coefficients, such a pattern forces irrationality: the right block makes a scaled tail small, and the left block isolates a single nonzero term. We first give the resulting classification, then the tail argument. Residues in the following sum are their least nonnegative representatives; they are coefficients of a binary series and need not be binary digits.

Theorem 4.1 (Residue series and dyadic observables). [Lean](#) · [Comparator](#) For every $m \geq 3$,

[Lean](#)
[Comparator](#)

$$\sum_{n \geq 1} \frac{\varphi(n) \bmod m}{2^n} \notin \mathbb{Q}.$$

For $k \geq 1$ and $f : \mathbb{Z}/2^k\mathbb{Z} \rightarrow \mathbb{Q}$, the series $\sum_{n \geq 1} f(\varphi(n) \bmod 2^k) 2^{-n}$ is rational exactly when f is constant on the even residue classes. If that constant is c , its value is $3f(1)/4 + c/4$.

Modulo two the sum is $3/4$, since $\varphi(n)$ is even for $n \geq 3$. More generally only $f(1)$ and the even residue classes occur in the second assertion. The pattern used in its proof is

$$\underbrace{0, \dots, 0}_{L \text{ terms}}, \quad a_N \neq 0, \quad \underbrace{0, \dots, 0}_{L \text{ terms}}.$$

The coefficients outside these blocks may have either sign. Their uniform bound is what makes the following argument possible.

Lemma 4.2 (An isolated nonzero coefficient between long zero blocks). [Lean](#) · [Comparator](#) Let $a_n \in \mathbb{Z}$ satisfy $|a_n| \leq C$. Suppose that for arbitrarily large L there is $N > L$ such that $a_N \neq 0$ and $a_{N+t} = 0$ for $0 < |t| \leq L$. Then $\sum_{n \geq 1} a_n 2^{-n}$ is irrational.

[Lean](#)
[Comparator](#)

Proof. Suppose that the sum has denominator $q \geq 1$. Multiplying it by 2^j and removing its finite integer prefix shows that every scaled tail $T_j = \sum_{t \geq 1} a_{j+t} 2^{-t}$ belongs to $q^{-1}\mathbb{Z}$. Choose a pattern with $C2^{-L} < 1/q$. The block on the right gives

$$|T_N| \leq C \sum_{t > L} 2^{-t} = C2^{-L} < 1/q.$$

The only element of $q^{-1}\mathbb{Z}$ in this interval is zero, so $T_N = 0$. Now start before the left block. The next L coefficients vanish, and the entire contribution after a_N has just been shown to be zero. Consequently

$$T_{N-L-1} = a_N 2^{-L-1}, \quad 0 < |T_{N-L-1}| \leq C2^{-L-1} < 1/q,$$

contradicting $T_{N-L-1} \in q^{-1}\mathbb{Z}$. □

For example, the indicator of the squares satisfies the lemma. An eventually periodic sequence with infinitely many nonzero terms does not have isolated coefficients at arbitrarily large distances. The uniform bound C is essential to this argument.

Proof of Theorem 4.1. Fix a unit $s \pmod{m}$ and a positive integer L . Choose distinct primes $q_t \equiv 1 \pmod{m}$, all exceeding L , for $0 < |t| \leq L$. The congruences

$$p \equiv s \pmod{m}, \quad p \equiv -t \pmod{q_t} \quad (0 < |t| \leq L)$$

define a reduced progression, since s is a unit modulo m and $0 < |t| < q_t$. CRT and Dirichlet's theorem therefore allow us to choose an arbitrarily large prime $p > L + 1$ on this progression, with $m \mid \varphi(p + t)$ at every neighbour and $\varphi(p) \equiv s - 1 \pmod{m}$ at the centre.

For a rational-valued function f on the residue classes, subtract $f(0)$ and multiply by a common denominator of its values. Since $\sum_{n \geq 1} 2^{-n} = 1$, these operations preserve whether the sum is rational. If $f(s - 1) \neq f(0)$, the resulting bounded integer sequence has an isolated nonzero coefficient for every L , so the lemma applies. For the least-residue map we take $s = -1$ and obtain the nonzero residue $m - 2$ when $m \geq 3$. When $m = 2^k$, each even residue r is of the form $s - 1$ with s a unit, so nonconstancy on the even classes gives an irrational sum by the same argument. Conversely, if f is constant there, all terms after $n = 2$ equal c and we obtain $3f(1)/4 + c/4$. $\square$

The first assertion is also an application of Erdős's sparse-series criterion [6, Lem. 1, p. 213], and of Kaneko, Suzuki and Tachiya [7, Thm. 3]. The nonzero residues occur on a set of density zero: an integer in that set has no prime divisor $p \equiv 1 \pmod{m}$. Wong gave the case in which the base equals the modulus [5]. The isolated-coefficient argument above also treats signed values of $f - f(0)$, for which those nonnegative sparse-series criteria need an additional spacing hypothesis. The [extension to other bases](#) treats every integer $t \geq 2$ and proves rational linear independence of 1 and $\sum_n (\varphi(n) \bmod m) t^{-dn}$, $d \geq 1$.

A Further consequences for the sections

The finite-level theorem also describes the full dyadic kernel. The notation below specialises the base to two.

Corollary A.1 (Dyadic basis). [Lean](#) · [Comparator](#) *The family*

[Lean](#)
[Comparator](#)

$$\{\varphi_{0,0}, \varphi_{1,0}\} \cup \{\varphi_{j,r} : j \geq 1, 0 < r < 2^j, r \text{ odd}\}, \quad \varphi_{j,r}(n) = \varphi(2^j n + r),$$

is a basis for the rational span of the full dyadic kernel. Every rational relation is generated by the scalar reductions. The complete level-zero truncation has dimension one.

Proof. Each finite subset of this family is contained in some $\mathcal{B}_{2,e}$. Theorem 1.1 gives independence, and its reductions give spanning. At level zero the sole section $\varphi(n)$ is nonzero, since $\varphi(1) = 1$. $\square$

The affine argument also permits periodic coefficients by restriction to their common residue classes.

Corollary A.2 (Periodic coefficients). [Lean](#) · [Comparator](#) Let $L_1, \dots, L_s$ be pairwise nonproportional affine forms with integer coefficients and positive slopes. If $w_1, \dots, w_s$ are rational-valued periodic sequences, then

[Lean](#)
[Comparator](#)

$$\sum_i w_i(n) \varphi(L_i(n)) = 0 \quad \text{for all sufficiently large } n \implies w_i(n) = 0 \quad \text{for every } i, n.$$

Proof. We choose a common period Q and restrict to $n = r + Qt$. The coefficients are now the constants $w_i(r)$, and the cross determinants are $Q(a_i b_j - a_j b_i) \neq 0$. By shifting t beyond the given threshold we can apply affine independence, obtaining $w_i(r) = 0$ for every i . We repeat this for each residue r ; periodicity then gives the conclusion even at the indices preceding the threshold. $\square$

Proportional forms are excluded for a reason: the identity $\varphi(4n + 2) = \varphi(2n + 1)$ would otherwise contradict the conclusion. Martin's theorem gives the same corollary on each progression [4, Thm. 1].

Coons's proof of nonregularity counts the poles of $\zeta(s - 1)/\zeta(s)$ [2, Cor. 3.1, Thm. 3.2]. For an integer-valued sequence, finite dimension of the rational kernel span is equivalent to finite generation of its integral kernel module: choose finitely many evaluations that embed the span in $\mathbb{Q}^d$; the module embeds in $\mathbb{Z}^d$, whose subgroups are finitely generated (compare [3, App. A]). Theorem 1.1 recovers this nonregularity and gives the ranks of its finite truncations. For an account of the earlier separation method, see Allouche, Shallit and Yassawi [13, Thm. 3, Ex. 4, Rem. 7].

These facts have a functional consequence. A k -Mahler equation has the form $\sum_{i=0}^d P_i(z) F(z^{k^i}) = 0$, with $P_i \in \mathbb{Q}[z]$ and $P_0 \neq 0$. The height theorem of Adamczewski, Bell and Smertnig implies that a k -Mahler series with integer coefficients of polynomial growth is k -regular [16, Thm. 1.2(b)]. Since $\varphi(n) \leq n$, its logarithmic height is at most $\log n$, so $F_\varphi(z) = \sum_{n \geq 1} \varphi(n) z^n$ has no such equation. Bell and Smertnig's multiplicative classification gives the same conclusion [14, Thm. 1.3]. Bell, Bruin and Coons treat related algebraic and D -finite series, the latter satisfying a linear differential equation with polynomial coefficients [15, Thms. 1.5–1.6]. These statements concern the function, and do not determine $F_\varphi(1/2)$.

The section operators $T_i g(n) = g(kn + i)$ satisfy

$$T_i F_{j,r} = F_{j+1, k^j i + r}, \quad V_{k,e+1} = V_{k,e} + \sum_{i=0}^{k-1} T_i V_{k,e}.$$

To obtain the second identity, write every residue at level $j + 1$ as $k^j i + r$. For a positive retained residue, the resulting section is again retained. For the two zero-residue generators, use $T_i F_{0,0} = F_{1,i}$ and $T_i F_{1,0} = F_{2,ki}$ followed by the zero-residue or scalar reduction. We thus obtain a positive integer multiple of a basis element in every case, although the increasing dimensions prevent any finite truncation from being invariant. The growth formula using the joint spectral radius for finite-dimensional regular sequences [3, Thm. 1, Prop. 4, Cor. 7] therefore does not apply to φ .

B The binary totient series

The proof of Theorem 4.1 uses boundedness where a long zero block makes the tail small. For S , the estimate $0 \leq \varphi(n) \leq n$ proves convergence, but forcing $2^L \mid \varphi(N + L)$ with $N + L > 1$ already requires $2^L \leq N + L - 1$. The tail bound $(N + L + 2)2^{-L}$ then exceeds 1. Thus this divisibility construction does not supply the small nonzero tail needed to exclude a rational value. We consider instead a finite test for differences of scaled tails.

Put $R_N = \sum_{j \geq 1} \varphi(N + j)2^{-j}$ and $\Delta_h(N) = R_{N+h} - R_N$. Subtracting the finite-prefix identities for $2^{N+h}S$ and $2^N S$ gives

$$\Delta_h(N) \equiv 2^N(2^h - 1)S \pmod{\mathbb{Z}}. \quad (2)$$

If $S = a/(2^c v)$, with v odd, then $\Delta_h(N)$ is integral for $N \geq c$ and $h = \varphi(v)$. To disprove rationality it therefore suffices to find a nonintegral difference beyond every threshold for each positive h .

For $h, N, L \in \mathbb{N}$, define the integer

$$D_{h,N,L} = \sum_{j=0}^{L-1} (\varphi(N + h + 1 + j) - \varphi(N + 1 + j))2^{L-1-j}, \quad B = N + h + L + 2.$$

Since $0 \leq R_M \leq M + 2$, we have

$$2^L \Delta_h(N) - D_{h,N,L} = R_{N+h+L} - R_{N+L}, \quad |2^L \Delta_h(N) - D_{h,N,L}| \leq B. \quad (3)$$

The difference is bounded by the larger tail bound. Hence the finite inequality

$$B < D_{h,N,L} \pmod{2^L} < 2^L - B \quad (4)$$

forces $\Delta_h(N) \notin \mathbb{Z}$. Conversely, if its distance to $\mathbb{Z}$ is positive, choose L so that $2^L \|\Delta_h(N)\|_{\mathbb{R}/\mathbb{Z}} > 2B$; the same error estimate gives (4). Thus allowing an unrestricted depth loses no nonintegral difference. For example, $D_{1,12,16} = -143140$ has residue 53468 modulo 2^{16} , and $B = 31$, so it excludes denominators dividing 2^{12} .

B.1 Equivalent residue conditions

We write $K(h, N, L)$ for (4).

Theorem B.1 (Propagation of one nonintegral tail difference). [Lean · Comparator](#) Fix $d \geq 1$ and $N \geq 0$. If $\Delta_d(N) \notin \mathbb{Z}$, then every sufficiently late pair $\{t, t + 1\}$ contains an m such that $K(md, N, md)$ holds. Consequently [Lean Comparator](#)

$$\exists t \geq 1 : K(td, N, td) \iff \Delta_d(N) \notin \mathbb{Z}.$$

Requiring this for every $d \geq 1, N \geq 0$ is equivalent to $S \notin \mathbb{Q}$.

The proof uses the recurrence $\Delta_{(t+1)d}(N) \equiv 2^d \Delta_{td}(N) + \Delta_d(N) \pmod{\mathbb{Z}}$; it is given in [Appendix A of the long record](#). A single pair d, N need not imply irrationality; the final assertion requires every positive d and every $N \geq 0$.

For a hypothetical denominator $2^c v$, a second test uses the modulus $M = (2^H - 1)/v$, where H is a positive multiple of $\varphi(v)$. Write $B_{H,c} = \sum_{j=0}^{H-1} \varphi(c + 1 + j)2^{H-1-j}$.

Equivalent formulation B.2 (A residue test modulo a divisor of $2^H - 1$). The series S is irrational if and only if, for every $c \geq 0$ and odd $v \geq 1$, some positive multiple H of $\varphi(v)$ satisfies

$$c + H + 1 < (-B_{H,c}) \bmod M < M - (c + H + 1). \quad (5)$$

The [proof and residue recurrence](#) use $B_{H,c} = M(vR_c) - \Delta_H(c)$ and the linear tail bound. Neither test provides these universal witnesses. A separate [Farey-interval calculation](#) at depth 240 excludes $S = a/q$ for $0 < q \leq Q_0 \approx 7.96 \times 10^{34}$.

B.2 Comparison sequences

Large ranks alone cannot settle the series question. There is an integer sequence c with $0 \leq c(n) \leq n$, unchanged odd totients and $|c(n) - \varphi(n)| \leq 2$ at even indices, for which $\sum c(n)2^{-n} = 5/4$. Its integral carry still has dyadic rank at least $2^e - 1$ through every positive level. The [construction and its limitations](#) explain why it fails the exact prime-dilation laws of φ . The same section retains the cofinal LCM-diagonal criterion, its endpoint sign conditions and the limits of finite integer combinations of shifts.

The ordinary [signed interpolation argument](#) permits any value in an interval about $\sum \varphi(n)\beta^{-n}$, for each integer $\beta \geq 2$, while preserving a prescribed prefix and every odd coefficient, with errors bounded by any positive $f(n) \rightarrow \infty$. The changed even indices have upper Banach density zero. On each fixed progression the Dirichlet defect is entire; at roots of unity the generating-function defect has smooth radial data and any prescribed finite jets vanish. This argument has not been formalised in Lean. It preserves Dirichlet singularities; regular parts and zeros may change, and finite jets do not determine an entire radial germ. It therefore supplies no cancellation estimate for the unchanged totient.

Rational approximation imposes a different requirement. The identity

$$\Theta_2 := \sum_{d \geq 1} \frac{\mu(d)}{(2^d - 1)^2} = S - \frac{1}{2}$$

was posted by Amiram Eldar, together with its coprimality interpretation, on 15 March 2026 [8], and by Steve Fan on 16 May 2026 [9]. Consider the rational quotients

$$Q(e, Y) = \frac{(\sum_{d \leq Y} \mu(d) / (2^d - 1)^{e+2})^2}{\sum_{d \leq Y} \mu(d) / (2^d - 1)^{2e+2}}.$$

Theorem B.3 (A lower bound for the rank-one quotients). [Lean · Comparator](#) For $e \geq 1$ and $Y \geq 4$, the denominator of $Q(e, Y)$ is positive, and the unique minimiser is $(e, Y) = (1, 5)$. Every admissible quotient and every nonempty finite positive weighted average of such quotients satisfies

$$Q - \Theta_2 > \frac{21}{320}.$$

The uniform bound $Q - \Theta_2 > 1/15$ is false already at $(1, 5)$.

The [proof](#) bounds geometric tails and compares seven-term rational prefixes. The averaging assertion applies after division; signed combinations, coupling before division and higher-rank kernels remain separate questions. A proposed family p_j/q_j in lowest terms would need $0 < q_j|\Theta_2 - p_j/q_j| \rightarrow 0$, which convergence alone does not imply.

[Lean](#)
[Comparator](#)

C An exponential-sum question

For every $h \geq 1$ and every X_0 , suppose that some integers $X \geq \max(X_0, 1)$ and $L \geq h$ satisfy

$$16(2X + h + L + 2) \leq 2^L, \quad \operatorname{Re} \sum_{N=X}^{2X-1} \exp(2\pi i D_{h,N,L}/2^L) \leq \frac{9}{10}X. \quad (6)$$

These inequalities would prove irrationality. Indeed, if every residue failed (4), each phase would be within $1/16$ of an integer, so every real part would be at least $\cos(\pi/8) > 9/10$. A certificate must therefore occur on the block, and (2) excludes every rational denominator by choosing its period and then a sufficiently late block.

To separate the counting estimates from the cancellation estimate, we single out one totient in each window. Fix $h, s \geq 1, L \geq s + h, X \geq 1$ and $0 < \eta < 1$, and put $t = L - s + 1$ and $E_N = \exp(2\pi i D_{h,N,L}/2^L)$. For $X \leq N < 2X$, let p_N be the largest prime factor of $N + t$ and $m_N = (N + t)/p_N$. Define

$$\begin{aligned} \mathcal{A} &= \{N \in [X, 2X) : m_N \leq \lfloor \sqrt{X}/2 \rfloor, p_N > 2\lfloor \sqrt{X} \rfloor\}, \\ \mathcal{G} &= \{N \in \mathcal{A} : \varphi(m_N) \geq \eta m_N\}. \end{aligned}$$

All indices are integers. On $\mathcal{A}$ we have $p_N > m_N$, so $\varphi(N + t) = \varphi(m_N)(p_N - 1)$. Its coefficient in the phase is $(2^h - 1)/2^t$. Write

$$z_N = \exp\left(\frac{2\pi i (2^h - 1)\varphi(m_N)(p_N - 1)}{2^t}\right), \quad w_N = E_N/z_N,$$

and let $\bar{z}_m$ be the average over the indices in $\mathcal{A}$ with cofactor m , with value zero for an empty set. The four proposed bounds are

$$\begin{aligned} \operatorname{Re} \sum_{N \in \mathcal{G}} w_N (z_N - \bar{z}_{m_N}) &\leq \frac{14}{25}X, \\ \left| \sum_{N \in \mathcal{G}} w_N \bar{z}_{m_N} \right| &\leq \frac{1}{100}X, \\ \left| \sum_{N \in \mathcal{A} \setminus \mathcal{G}} E_N \right| &\leq \frac{1}{100}X, \\ \left| \sum_{\substack{X \leq N < 2X \\ N \notin \mathcal{A}}} E_N \right| &\leq \frac{8}{25}X. \end{aligned} \quad (7)$$

Before taking real parts and absolute values, the four sums add to $\sum E_N$, and hence their bounds imply the real-part estimate $9X/10$ in (6). We have only added and subtracted the group means, without any independence assumption. The resulting bound concerns the real part, and does not give a $21X/25$ bound for the absolute value of the full sum.

Problem C.1 (Four estimates for the first-harmonic sum). For each $h \geq 1$, do there exist $s \geq 1$ and $0 < \eta < 1$ such that, for every X_0 , there are X, L with

$$\max(X_0, 1) \leq X, \quad h \leq L - s, \quad 16(2X + h + L + 2) \leq 2^L,$$

for which those four bounds hold?

All four estimates must hold on the same block with the same parameters. For each fixed h, s , take the least admissible L satisfying the room inequality and $L \geq s + h$. The [smooth-number and small-cofactor estimates](#) give the last two bounds for all sufficiently large X when $0 < \eta < 1/(300 \log 4)$. The elementary excluded-cofactor estimate is $(3\eta \log 4 + o(1))X$; it needs no prime number theorem. The group-mean and weighted mean-subtracted estimates remain open. No optimality is asserted for the sufficient margins in (7).

Alternatively, at $s = 26$, $\eta = 1/1000$ and minimal depth one has $|G| > 67X/100$ for large X . The single open estimate $\text{Re} \sum_{N \in G} E_N \leq 603X/1000$, for each h on arbitrarily large blocks, would suffice by the same argument. The [ordinary comparison argument](#) gives larger first harmonics at all sufficiently large admissible scales, distinguishing its rational sequences from the cancellation required of φ . Its proof is included with the interpolation construction.

Balasubramanian, Giri and Srivastav give correlation estimates applicable to $\varphi(n)/n$, uniformly for $|h| \leq x/2$ [11, Thm. 2.2]. Here the modulus grows with L , and the residual weight depends on other totient values in the window. That correlation theorem supplies neither of the two remaining estimates. Establishing them for the actual totient is the unresolved arithmetic step.

Verification. *Formal proofs.* A result with a kernel-checked Lean proof carries links beside its heading and in the margin; both open the same evidence. *Lean* opens the proof: the declaration itself when one declaration states the whole result, otherwise the list of declarations that together state it. Inline citations to individual declarations elsewhere may identify ingredients of a proof. *Comparator* opens the recorded comparison, in which the same statement, written again from Mathlib alone in a separate repository, was compared with our proof by Lean’s Comparator tool, allowing only the three standard axioms. *Comparator pending* means that the complete statement has no recorded comparison yet. A dagger on the Lean mark means that the Lean proof assumes an input named just below the result. A result without a mark has no Lean proof of its whole statement; what is checked is said below it. The [evidence record](#) gives every declaration, version and check. Comparator checks statements, axioms and kernel acceptance; it does not establish novelty or peer review. These checks show that the stated propositions are proved; whether they are the right propositions is a question the reader can settle by comparing them with the text. The [declaration guide](#) preserves the individual formal-source links for the short paper, including the three results whose full proofs appear in Appendix A of the long record. The displayed arguments and the signed interpolation proof are to be read as ordinary mathematical proofs. Recorded Lean and Comparator checks refer to their exact declarations and source versions; this revision makes no claim of a new formal run or independent review.

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